Lesson 51: Word Forms, Prefixes and Suffixes

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 6.4 Word Form: Adjectives and Adverbs / Prefixes and Suffixes; 6.6 Working with Words (Exercises).

In this lesson

You will use adjectives and adverbs correctly, form comparatives and superlatives (including good, well, bad and badly), learn ten common prefixes and five suffix spelling rules, and then review the whole chapter on words. Precise comparisons ("more likely", "the most effective") are everywhere in academic writing, and prefixes and suffixes help you understand and spell new words in your psychology reading.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose between an adjective and an adverb, including good / well and bad / badly.
- Form the comparative and superlative of regular and irregular adjectives and adverbs.
- Use the meanings of ten common prefixes to understand and build words.
- Spell words correctly when you add a suffix.
- Proofread a paragraph for word-form, confused-word and spelling errors.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
adjective	describes a noun or pronoun; answers which one? what kind? how many?	The green sweater belongs to Iris.
adverb	describes a verb, an adjective or another adverb; answers how? to what extent? why? when? where?	Bertrand sings horribly.
linking verb	a verb such as be, look, feel or seem that is followed by an adjective describing the subject	She looks beautiful.
comparative	the form that compares two people or things	Steven is thinner than Jorge.
superlative	the form that compares more than two	Fatoumata is the loudest cheerleader on the squad.
prefix	a word part added to the beginning of a word to create a new meaning	mis + spell = misspell
suffix	a word part added to the end of a word	dark + ness = darkness

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
root word	the word before a prefix or suffix is added	care in caring, careful
silent e	a final e that is not pronounced	care, use, replace
accent (stress)	the syllable said with more force	re·GRET, CAN·cel

Rules and explanations

Adjectives and adverbs

- An **adjective** describes a noun or pronoun: "The **green** sweater belongs to Iris." After a linking verb, the adjective describes the subject: "She looks **beautiful**."
- An **adverb** describes a verb, an adjective or another adverb: "Bertrand sings **horribly**." "My sociology instructor is **extremely** wise." "He threw the ball **very** accurately." Most adverbs are formed by adding -ly to an adjective.

Comparatives and superlatives

Word	Comparative (two)	Superlative (more than two)
one syllable: add -er / -est	big: bigger, fast: faster	biggest, fastest
two or more syllables: more / most	more comfortable, more happily	most comfortable, most jealous
two syllables ending in -y: change y to i	happier, healthier	happiest, healthiest

(The book gives the -y exception only for superlatives; it applies to comparatives too.) Use "than" after a comparative and "the" before a superlative. Never use both forms together, such as "more" with -er.

Irregular forms: good, well, bad, badly

		Comparative	Superlative
adjective	good	better	best
adverb	well	better	best
adjective	bad	worse	worst
adverb	badly	worse	worst

- Incorrect: Cecilia felt that she had never done so ~~good~~ on a test. Correct: ...done so **well** on a test.
- Incorrect: Cecilia's team received a ~~well~~ score. Correct: ...received a **good** score.
- Incorrect: I did ~~bad~~ on my accounting test. Correct: I did **badly**...
- Incorrect: The coming thunderstorm looked ~~badly~~. Correct: ...looked **bad**.
- **Better** and **worse** compare two people or things; **best** and **worst** compare three or more.

(The book says "well" is "always an adverb". It is also an adjective meaning "healthy": "I don't feel well today.")

Prefixes

The main rule: do not add letters or leave out letters (dis + satisfied = dissatisfied; mis + spell = misspell).

Prefix	Meaning	Example
dis	not, opposite of	dissatisfied
mis	wrongly	misspell
un	not	unacceptable
re	again	reelection
inter	between	interrelated
pre	before	prepay
non	not	nonsense
super	above	superscript
sub	under	submerge
anti	against, opposing	antibacterial

Suffix rules

Rule	Examples	Exceptions
1. With -ness and -ly, the word does not change.	darkness, scholarly	consonant + y: change y to i (readily, happiness)
2. Suffix begins with a vowel: drop the silent e.	caring, usable	after ce or ge, keep the e before a or o (replaceable, courageous)
3. Suffix begins with a consonant: keep the silent e.	careful, careless	truly, argument
4. Consonant + y: change y to i, unless the suffix begins with i.	sunnier	hurrying (the suffix -ing begins with i, so the y stays)
5. Suffix begins with a vowel: double the final consonant only if the word has one syllable or is stressed on the last syllable, **and** it ends in one vowel + one consonant.	tanning, regretting, preferred	canceled (CAN·cel: stress not on the last syllable; British English writes cancelled)

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic builds words mainly from roots and patterns (k-t-b: kataba, kitab, maktab), while English often adds prefixes and suffixes. Learn whole word families (succeed, success, successful, successfully) so that you do not use the right root in the wrong form ("a well score", "she is very success").

Practice

Exercise 1. Six comparative and superlative errors. In the lesson material, read the paragraph that begins "Our argument started on the most sunny afternoon..." and correct the six errors.

Exercise 2. Good, well, bad or badly?

1. Fasika always felt _____ if she did not see the sun in the morning.
2. The school board president gave a _____ speech for once.
3. Although my dog, Comet, is mischievous, he always behaves _____ at the dog park.
4. I thought my back injury was _____ at first, but it turned out to be minor.
5. Razak was shaking _____ from the extreme cold.
6. Apple crisp is a very _____ dessert that can be made using whole grains instead of white flour.
7. The meeting with my son's math teacher went very _____.
8. Juan has a _____ appetite, especially when it comes to dessert.
9. Magritte thought the guests had a _____ time at the party because most people left early.
10. She _____ wanted to win the writing contest prize, which included a trip to New York.

Exercise 3. Comparative or superlative? Write the correct form of the word in brackets.

1. This research paper is _____ (good) than my last one.
2. Grace likes country music _____ (well) of all.
3. My motorcycle rides _____ (bad) than it did last summer.
4. That is the _____ (bad) joke my father ever told.
5. The hockey team played _____ (badly) than it did last season.
6. Heejoo plays guitar _____ (well) than she plays the piano.
7. It will go down as one of the _____ (bad) movies I have ever seen.
8. The deforestation in the Amazon is _____ (bad) than it was last year.
9. Movie ticket sales are _____ (good) this year than last.
10. My husband says mystery novels are the _____ (good) types of books.

Exercise 4. Words with prefixes. Read the paragraph about the lost orange sock in the lesson material ("At first, I thought one of my fuzzy, orange socks disappeared..."). Find the five words with prefixes and write their meanings.

Exercise 5. Add a prefix.

1. I wanted to ease my stomach _____comfort, so I drank some ginger root tea.
2. Lenny looked funny in his _____matched shirt and pants.
3. Hang felt _____glamorous at the party because she was the only one not wearing a dress.
4. My mother said those _____aging creams do not work, so I should not waste my money on them.
5. The child's _____standard performance on the test alarmed his parents.

6. When my sister first saw the meteor, she thought it was a _____natural phenomenon.
7. Even though she got an excellent job offer, Mariam did not want to _____locate to a different country.
8. With a small class size, the students get to _____act with the teacher more frequently.
9. I slipped on the ice because I did not heed the _____cautions about watching my step.
10. A _____combatant is another word for civilian.

Exercise 6. Add the suffix. 1. refer + ed 2. refer + ence 3. mope + ing 4. approve + al 5. green + ness 6. benefit + ed 7. resubmit + ing 8. use + age 9. greedy + ly 10. excite + ment

Review exercises. These are in "Working with Words (Exercises)" in the lesson material.

Exercise 7 (its Exercise 5). Write the comparative or superlative of the word in brackets (items 1-10, "Deniz has a (cheerful) _____ outlook...").

Exercise 8 (its Exercise 1). Proofread the paragraph about grunge music and correct the commonly confused and misspelled words.

Exercise 9 (its Exercise 2). Choose the correct homonym or frequently misspelled word (items 1-10, "William asked me a serious question...").

Exercise 10 (its Exercise 4). Choose the synonym. 1. lenient (relaxed, callous) 2. abandon (vacate, deceive) 3. berate (criticize, encourage) 4. experienced (callow, matured) 5. spiteful (malevolent, mellow) 6. tame (subdued, wild) 7. tasty (savory, bland) 8. banal (common, interesting) 9. contradict (deny, revolt) 10. vain (boastful, simple)

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my rewrite of the personal essay in Working with Words, Exercise 3 ('My biggest regret happened in high school...'): [paste]. Have I replaced all the slang, clichés and general words?"
- "Give me ten terms from my psychology course with prefixes, such as nonverbal, subconscious and interpersonal. I will guess each meaning from the prefix. Then correct me."
- "Quiz me on word families: you say a word (succeed, analyze, rely, compare), and I give the noun, verb, adjective and adverb."
- "Check my eight sentences with good, well, bad, badly, better, best, worse and worst. Are they formal enough for an employer?"

Read aloud

Say each group; notice that the consonant doubles only when the stress stays on the last syllable of the root.

1. re·FER, re·FERRED, REF·er·ence
2. pre·FER, pre·FERRED, PREF·er·ence
3. re·GRET, re·GRET·ting
4. CAN·cel, CAN·celed; BEN·e·fit, BEN·e·fit·ed

5. Cecilia felt that she had never done so well on a test.
6. Better and worse compare two persons or things; best and worst compare three or more.

Writing task

Part A (the book's task). In a formal, business-like tone, write eight separate sentences, one with each of these words: good, well, bad, badly, better, best, worse, worst. Imagine that a current or future employer will read and judge them.

Part B. Write a paragraph of 150-200 words that compares two ways to study for an exam, for example rereading your notes and testing yourself (memory is a topic in PSYC 110). Use at least four comparative or superlative forms and at least three words with prefixes from the table.

Self-editing checklist:

- Did I use an adjective after linking verbs (be, look, feel, seem) and an adverb to say how something is done?
- Are good and bad adjectives, and well and badly adverbs?
- -er / -est for one syllable, more / most for two or more (except two-syllable words ending in -y)?
- No double forms such as "more smarter" or "most dumbest"?
- Better / worse for two things, best / worst for three or more; "than" after comparatives, "the" before superlatives?
- Did I add each prefix without adding or dropping letters?
- Did I follow the suffix rules for silent e, final y and doubled consonants?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. the most sunny afternoon: the sunniest afternoon
2. more smart than: smarter than
3. the most dumbest dog: the dumbest dog
4. I was angrier about a bad grade: I was angry about a bad grade (nothing is compared)
5. I had been more mean: I had been meaner
6. the most sorry person: the sorriest person

Exercise 2

1. bad (after the linking verb "felt")
2. good ("bad" is also grammatically correct)
3. well
4. bad
5. badly
6. good
7. well ("badly" is also grammatically correct)
8. good
9. bad
10. badly (= very much)

Exercise 3

1. better 2. best 3. worse 4. worst 5. worse 6. better 7. worst 8. worse 9. better 10. best

Exercise 4

1. disappeared (dis-, opposite of: stopped being visible; was lost)
2. prevent (pre-, before: stop something from happening; literally "come before")
3. discover (dis-, opposite of: uncover, find)
4. reclining (re-, here "back", not "again": leaning back)
5. supervise (super-, above, over: watch over and direct)

Exercise 5

1. discomfort 2. mismatched 3. unglamorous 4. antiaging (also written anti-aging) 5. substandard 6. supernatural 7. relocate 8. interact 9. precautions 10. noncombatant

Exercise 6

1. referred (stressed on the last syllable, re·FER: double the r)
2. reference (the stress moves to the first syllable, REF·er·ence, so the r is not doubled)
3. moping (drop the silent e)

4. approval (drop the silent e)
5. greenness (Rule 1: the word does not change)
6. benefited (stressed on the first syllable, BEN·e·fit: no doubling; "benefitted" is also used, mainly in British English)
7. resubmitting (stressed on the last syllable, re·sub·MIT: double the t)
8. usage (drop the silent e)
9. greedily (change y to i)
10. excitement (keep the silent e)

Exercise 7

1. more cheerful 2. best 3. most thoughtful 4. worst 5. strangest 6. better 7. sloppiest 8. worse 9. more smoothly (the verb "writes" needs an adverb; "smoother" is informal) 10. luckier

Exercise 8 (fifteen errors) quiet: quite; an: and; There: Their; striped: stripped; ware: wear; extravagent: extravagant; by: buy; they're: their; too: to; quit: quite; two: to; populer: popular; charecterized: characterized; conscience: conscious; buy: by

Exercise 9

1. then 2. lessen 3. loser 4. effects 5. Except 6. through 7. who's; who's 8. see 9. principal 10. patience; patients

Exercise 10

1. relaxed 2. vacate 3. criticize 4. matured 5. malevolent 6. subdued 7. savory 8. common 9. deny 10. boastful

My notes